

"FOR BETTER SERVICE, PEOPLE HAVE TO PAY POWER TARIFF AS PER THEIR USAGE. NO EXCUSES WILL BE ENTERTAINED"

—MANOJ SINHA
Lieutenant Governor, J&K

ets of Kashmir. Official data shows that, so far, about 200,000 and 190,000 meters have been installed in the two regions, respectively. In the Valley, any protest—mostly minor—was dealt with by snapping the power supply to those areas. In Jammu, however, amid a rising resentment, the authorities appointed 15 nodal officers to address the complaints. "We tested 5,000 meters in front of consumers," says Shiv Anant Tayal, managing director, Jammu Power Development Corporation, "and found that none was running fast." There were some software errors and they were rectified, he adds, but "no case of inflated bills was found".

Despite these measures and assurances, consumers in Jammu are not ready to give up. Finding the BJP cornered over the issue, its general secretary, Vibodh Gupta, led a party delegation to meet Sinha at Raj Bhawan on August 19, demanding a rollback. "We will meet the L-G again and press for it," he says, while blaming the National Conference and PDP for "misleading" people. L-G Sinha, however, has maintained that those with resources will have to pay power tariff as per their usage while the "poor will be taken care of by the administration". "No excuses will be entertained," he says. "To get better service, people have to pay their bills." With a stalemate at hand, the issue is likely to raise further tempers. ■



KARNATAKA

A DROUGHT WITHOUT RELIEF

By Ajay Sukumaran

Distress is mounting in Karnataka's farmlands. Pointing to his two-acre plot where his maize crop continues to wither, A. Manjunath, a farmer, laments that whatever harvest he gets will be fit only for fodder now. In July, when an erratic Southwest monsoon picked up in the hinterlands of Mysuru, it had brought hopes of raising a normal crop. Preparing the farm and sowing it had cost Manjunath Rs 15,000 an acre. If things had gone well, he could have grown 15 quintals of corn per acre. "It'd have fetched nothing less than Rs 25,000 an acre. Now, I won't even get Rs 5,000." Ironically, even as he says this, a faint drizzle descends from the overcast sky in his Ambale village. It can't save Manjunath's crop.

The dry spell in August, the worst in 123 years, has dealt a lethal blow to Karnataka's farmers. "About 50-75 per cent of the standing crop is gone," says Badagalapura Nagendra, leader of Karnataka Rajya Raitha Sangha, a farmer's body. "Some horticulture crops survived only because the groundwater level had improved in the last few years."

Karnataka last faced a widespread drought in 2018. The next four years brought plentiful rain, but things have turned grim again this season. About 79 per cent of the state's arable land is drought-prone. In fact, Karnataka has the second-largest area of dry land in the coun-